Chapter 1

Unfathomable Depths

Legends reveal that the Kashmir Valley was once submerged under water. Ancient texts have referred to the existence of a mountainous land, known by several names through history—Kashyapamir, Kashyapa Meru, Kashyapapur, Kasperia, Kaspapyros, Kaspatyros. Archaeologists have also traced the earliest signs of human life in the Indian subcontinent to Kashmir.

In 535 BC, the Persian Achaemenid Empire, under Cyrus the Great, extended its boundaries eastwards—almost to the Pir Panjal Mountain Range that divides Kashmir from the plains of the Indian subcontinent.

Alexander and Christ in Kashmir

Over 200 years later, in 326 BC, Alexander the Great, after conquering the Achaemenid Empire, turned his attention to India, which he believed was the end of the world. North-western India already formed the eastern part of the Achaemenid Empire, at this time.[1] He divided his invading army into two contingents: one entered the plains of India through the Khyber Pass and the other, led by him, crossed into India via the Hindu Kush mountain ranges, which the Greeks called Caucasus Indicus. After capturing the mountain fort of Aornos, which lay near present-day Swat, Alexander's contingent descended into the foothills of Jammu and Kashmir, where the